

rear of the phone at the extreme top left end—this placement is quite cumbersome, since you need to tilt the phone upwards to compose a perfect frame. The quality of the photos we took was decent. The face-morphing application provided with the phone is easy to use—you need to select four points on a face to be morphed, and then you just press a button. There are twelve effects such as ‘happy’, ‘angry’, etc, that can be applied, with five intensities to choose from.

The S670C supports WAP and GPRS for Internet connectivity, but lacks infrared or Bluetooth support. The package provides a serial cable for PC connectivity.

Do I need a colour phone?

For many cell phone users today, especially among the younger lot, the display is as important as the phone itself. Until as recently as last year, cell phones with colour screens were very expensive, with most of them offering not more than 4K colours, a paltry feature compared to what we have today. With the prices of colour phones taking a nosedive, you can easily afford one today for less than Rs 10,000.

But the question is, do you really need a colour phone, or should you stick to a regular model? Since there are several handsets in the market that still have mono screens with a variety of backlight options, one should be cautious instead of blindly jumping for a colour phone.

If you decide to buy a basic mono screen phone, make sure that the backlight doesn't hurt the eyes, and that the text is easily readable. Your best bet is to opt for a handset with a white backlight. A white backlight doesn't put much stress on your eyes when you read text. Many users are comfortable using a green backlight, but strictly avoid a blue backlight—the text hardly stands out against the blue background of the screen.

For colour phones, 4K colour screens are an option. Phones with 4K colour are good enough for normal usage and playing games as well. Though it is a pleasant change from bland mono screens, don't expect great-looking, articulate images on these cell phones.

For a person who is into MMS and e-mail, and is obsessed with flashy wallpapers and themes, 65K colours is the bare minimum. A 65K colour screen supports multi-coloured wallpapers, themes and images that you receive from friends, or click with your own inbuilt camera.

There are a few models in the market, such as the Pantech G500, which go a big step further for the screen-freak, providing 262K colour screens. Images on such screens are nothing less than a feast for the eyes. The exquisite colour saturation and vivid details can be a captivating experience. 262K colour screens make games look much more lively and colourful.

Samsung and Motorola have come up with models with 65K OLED screens. Though this technology has been around for quite some time, OLED (Organic LED) has only recently been taking to the mainstream. These screens run on much lesser power (two to ten volts, depending on the size) than the more widely used TFT LCD screens. OLED screens improve readability considerably in daylight. Cell phones with this feature are particularly handy for users who're looking for, both, great usability as well as long battery life.

LG G5300i

Price: Rs 8,500 **A**

LG's G5300i is priced at Rs 8,500. It offers a good balance of features and performance. It will probably see stiff competition from Nokia's older 6610, which has nearly the same feature set, save 64K colour support.

This phone is compact enough to easily fit into your pocket. Build quality is great and the phone feels rugged—comparable to Nokia's 3310, in this respect..

The phone's looks are somewhat controversial, in the sense that there can be contrasting views—some may like it, some may not. The silver body has bits of chrome lining the edges. Blue, smoked translucent plastic runs down the middle of the keypad, and creates some contrast with the silver. The menu-navigation keys are quite hard, but provide good audible feedback. The keypad is slightly cramped and the last line is hard to reach.

The display on this phone is quite small, but the 64K colour screen offers good colour depth. Watching the wallpapers in their full glory is fun. The 16 polyphonic ringtones are loud, but not loud enough for noisy areas. The vibrator is good, though.

The menu interface is good, too, but we'd like to see LG implementing a four-way directional keypad instead of the two-way button, which is difficult to use.

What we liked most about this phone is the Java support. You can install applications, melodies and games. The G5300i comes with GPRS and WAP support. Browsing the Net on the colour screen is fun.



LG G7100

Price: Rs 19,000 **C**

The G7100 is the top-of-the-line phone from LG which LG markets as the 'rotating camera' phone. It is very similar in size and shape to the G7030. At Rs 19,000, the G7100 is a good product for the price.

There are several good things about this clamshell phone—Java support, PC synchronisation using the provided cable, infrared, GPRS, and very good wallpapers and screensavers. The accompanying CD-ROM comes loaded with melodies, games and applications that can be installed via a PC.

The phone comes in a variety of colours. The keys are large and fun to use, and the response offered is perfect in every sense, making messaging a delight. The four-way keypad also accesses pre-defined shortcuts.

On the upper flip, you have a

